

Listening (auditory discrimination) games for your target speech sounds

What is auditory discrimination?

Auditory discrimination is the ability to recognize the difference between similar sounding speech sounds and words.

A child who has difficulties in auditory discrimination may have difficulty telling the difference between words and sounds that are different, for example 'k' and 't' or 'Sue' and 'two'. This problem can make it hard for children to understand what people are saying, particularly in noisy environments.

It can also impact upon speech development as a child who perceives sounds differently will find it difficult to articulate them correctly in words. Children who have difficulties with auditory discrimination can also be at risk of delayed literacy development.



What can you do to help?

If your child has difficulties with their speech and/or ability to hear sounds in words it is important to:

Get their hearing checked to rule out any form of hearing impairment that may be the cause of these difficulties. In many cases children do not have a hearing impairment. They just have difficulties in how they detect the subtleties between sounds.

Your Speech and Language Therapist will assess your child and advise you as to what sounds (and/or words) to work on. Once you have been given the sounds your child needs to work on please remember that you are working on the sound NOT the letter name, for example, say 's' and not 'ser' or 'ess'.

Try to encourage your child to listen to the sounds, provide a clear model of the sound and ask them to look at you as you say the sounds so they can see how the sounds are made. Try making the sound in front of a mirror.

Associating sounds with a letter or picture cue and talking about the characteristics of the speech sound is helpful i.e. whether the sound is long like 's' or short like 't'. This gives you and the child a language with which to talk about speech sounds and helps them to understand what to do.



Auditory discrimination games

Once you have been advised on what target sounds to work on and at what level (i.e. single sound, sound + vowel or word level) please try the following games using the appropriate picture cards or written letters.

Towers



Sound in isolation: You place your child's target sound cue card and contrast sound card on the table (e.g. 'k' versus 't'). You say one of the sounds and the child puts a brick on the correct sound picture or letter. How tall can you make the towers?

Make it harder: Add a vowel: Repeat the game but when you say the sound add in a vowel (e.g. kee, too, kar)
In words: Repeat the game but instead of saying single sounds, say words with the chosen sounds e.g. 'king' 'table' 'kiss'

Ball in the box



Sound in isolation: Using your target sounds, get a box or container and stick the sound cue cards or letters onto each of them. Use soft balls or socks tied in a knot. You say the sound and the child throws the ball into the matching box.

Make it harder: Add a vowel: Repeat the game but when you say the sound add in a vowel (e.g. kee, too, kar)
In words: Repeat the game but instead of saying single sounds, say words with the chosen sounds e.g. 'king' 'table' 'kiss'. Can the child identify the sound in the word?

Hide and seek



Sounds in isolation: Make three copies of each sound picture or letter you are working on. Hide them around the room or out in the garden or playground. Say a sound and the child must find the correct sound card.

Make it harder: Add a vowel: Repeat the game but when you say the sound, add in a vowel (e.g. kee, too, kar) In words: Repeat the game but instead of saying single sounds, say words which include the chosen sounds e.g. 'king' 'table' 'kiss'. Can your child find the correct sound card e.g. can they find a 'k' card when they hear 'king'?

Skittles

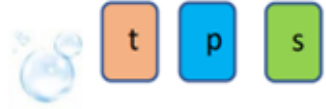


Sounds in isolation: Attach your target picture cards or letters to skittles and space them out. You say one of the sounds and see if the child can knock down the one you said.

Make it harder: Add a vowel: Repeat the game but when you say a sound, add in a vowel (e.g. kee, too, kar) In words: Repeat the game but instead of saying single sounds, say words including the chosen sounds e.g. 'king' 'table' 'kiss'.

Auditory discrimination games

Bubbles



Sound in isolation: Place your target picture cards or letters on the floor or stick them on the wall. Space them out. You say a sound and the child has to blow bubbles at the sound you say.

Make it harder: Add a vowel: Repeat the game but when you say a sound, add in a vowel (e.g. tee, soo, tar) Can they blow bubbles at the correct sound they hear?

In words: Repeat the game but instead of saying single sounds, say words with the chosen sounds e.g. 'pan' 'table' 'sun'

Islands

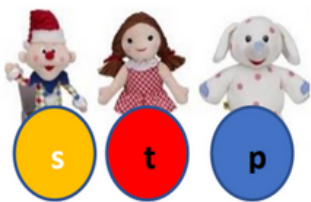


Sounds in isolation: Use multiple copies of your target picture cue cards or letters and place them on cushions or pillows to make islands a few feet apart from each other. You say a sound and the child must run to the right island. If they go wrong, they may get eaten by the shark!

Make it harder: Add a vowel: Repeat the game but when you say the sound, add in a vowel (e.g. kee, too, kar). Can they run to the correct island?

In words: Repeat the game but instead of saying single sounds, say words including the chosen sounds e.g. 'king' 'table' 'kiss'

Feed the toys



Sounds in isolation: Select a toy for each target sound you are working on e.g. a teddy and a doll. Tell your child that the toys like to eat different things, for example teddy only likes to eat 's' pictures and dolly only likes to eat 't' pictures. You have the sound cue cards and say to the child that you will say what is on the card (don't show the child what it is). Can they point to which toy it has to go to? If they can, they can feed the picture to the correct toy.

Make it harder: Add a vowel: Repeat the game but when you say the sound on your sound card also add in a vowel (e.g. kee, too, kar) In words: Repeat the game but use word/picture cards containing the target sounds.



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